On the following morning, 7 December, as a new parliamentary commission began investigating corruption under the old order, Honecker's mood spiralled downward when members of the security forces arrived to search his home. He noted bitterly:

The whole procedure upset me so much I was near a heart attack. A nurse was called, she diagnosed high blood pressure. We knew nothing of what they were looking for. Nothing was taken, except radios for our grandchildren. It was said after I had controlled myself, somewhat, that the search was carried out on the grounds of a deposition of the state prosecutor concerning abuse of trust.

Despite the fragility of the former General Secretary's health, he was also slapped with an eviction notice to quit Wandlitz by 31 January 1990.

Three days later, on 9 December, police officers returned to Wandlitz to ransack the lavishly appointed home of Stasi chief Erich Mielke, who almost had a stroke when being arrested in his kitchen. However, his tongue had lost none of its edge as he angrily accused his former underlings of being 'traitors'. At that very same moment, a few streets away, Willi Stoph was being placed in handcuffs as police officers carried out crates of fine whisky, French vintages and exotic liquors discovered in his cellar. Ordinary East Germans – aware that their leaders lived charmed lifestyles – were stunned by the deceit and dishonesty as details dribbled out.

After an unhappy Christmas cloistered in Wandlitz, Honecker was freed from house detention on 5 January 1990 and immediately sent to Berlin to undergo surgery to remove a malignant kidney tumour, leaving Margot and Sonja to pack and prepare the move. 'She had given away a great deal because, in the new dwelling, we did not need and could not use everything. The old house in Wandlitz no longer existed and we needed to look for a new one.' Margot turned down an offer of a two-roomed apartment on